



DESIGN SYSTEM

& Web Component Guidelines

Edition 1.0 — May 2026

Built to feed Claude Design (and any other design tool)

Informed by The Row · Lemaire · Toteme · Brunello Cucinelli · Loro Piana · Hermès · Aesop · 11.11 · Nicobar · Raw Mango

How to use this document

This document has six parts. Read them in order the first time. After that, use them as reference.

1. Part A — Claude Design quick-paste. Copy these three blocks into the Claude Design setup form.
2. Part B — Brand tokens. The atomic units: colour, type, spacing, borders. The primitives every component is built from.
3. Part C — Component library. Every UI element specified — buttons, inputs, cards, navigation, headers, footers.
4. Part D — Page layouts. The pages of the website and how they are composed, with explicit references to the quiet-luxury brands they descend from.
5. Part E — Anti-patterns. The things that would break MTSYA. Read this quarterly.
6. Part F — Reference brand studies. Each of the nine reference brands, what to take from them and what to leave.

If a designer or AI tool tries to override a specification in this document, they need to argue with the principle behind it, not just substitute a different value. The principles live in the brand book.

PART A

Claude Design — quick paste

Three text blocks ready to copy directly into the three editable fields on the Claude Design setup form. Plus the asset upload checklist.

A.1 Company name and blurb

Paste this into the 'Company name and blurb' field.

MTSYA — a quiet-luxury Indian menswear brand. Five plain shirts and five plain T-shirts in Egyptian Giza cotton × TENCEL Lyocell at ₹3,000. Named for Matsya, the first avatar of Vishnu — the fish that guided Manu's boat through the deluge. Brand promise: the wardrobe that endures the deluge.

A.2 Other notes

Paste this into the 'Any other notes' field. Long but worth it — gives Claude Design the full system.

BRAND VOICE

Calm, considered, never urgent. No exclamation marks. No marketing words like 'premium', 'luxury', 'curated', 'amazing', 'crafted'. Closer to a long-form magazine essay than a marketing email. Every page rewards a slow read.

COLOUR SYSTEM

Primary: Deep Ink #1F3A4D (75% of all text). Background: Paper Cream #F5F1EA (75% of every surface). Accent: Terracotta #C9603A (1% only — wax seals, single moments). Secondary text: Stone #5A6B78. Tertiary / dividers: Quiet #9DA8B2 / Rule #BFC4C9. Black #000000 only on care labels, never web.

TYPOGRAPHY

Wordmark: lowercase 'mtsya' in Adobe Caslon Pro Bold (or equivalent classical serif), wide letter-spacing (+200). Headlines + body: classical serif (Adobe Caslon Pro, Cormorant Garamond, or EB Garamond). Functional UI: sans-serif (Optima, Avenir, or Inter). Devanagari मत्स्यः Mukta Mahee.

LAYOUT

12-column grid, max 1440px content width, 24px gutters. 8px spacing scale only (8/16/24/48/96/128). Always more whitespace than feels comfortable. The Loro Piana / The Row generosity rule.

COMPONENTS

Buttons: square corners, no shadow, navy fill or navy outline. Inputs: bottom-border only, no full borders. Cards: no fill, no border, no shadow — just well-shot product image plus type. Image radius: 0 always. Icons: NEVER use icons in UI; use language instead (the cart link says 'bag', not a bag icon).

DON'T DO

Drop shadows. Gradients. Rounded corners > 2px. Carousels. Pop-ups. Stock photography. Animation on scroll. Sans-serif body text. Bold body text. Exclamation marks. Emojis in customer-facing copy.

REFERENCE BRANDS

If asked what MTSYA should look like, point to: therow.com (homepage discipline), lemaire.fr (product page), brunellocucinelli.com (storytelling pages), loropiana.com (material photography), aesop.com (typography hierarchy), 11-11.in (Indian quiet-luxury). MTSYA sits at the intersection of European quiet luxury and Indian craft luxury, at the ₹3,000 plain-shirt price point.

A.3 Asset uploads

Drag these files into the 'Add fonts, logos and assets' upload area.

- MTSYA_logo.png — the navy fish + mtsya wordmark (already in your MATSYA folder)
- Once commissioned: MTSYA logo SVG, fish-only SVG, fish + wordmark lockup SVG
- Once licensed: Adobe Caslon Pro font files, or your final wordmark serif
- Once shot: 5–10 hero photographs in the brand's photographic style (cream backgrounds, soft natural light)

A.4 What NOT to upload

- Stock photography — Claude Design will use it as a reference template otherwise
- Trend boards from Pinterest — Claude Design treats these as direction
- Logos of competing brands — even as 'inspiration', they pollute the model's understanding
- Sketches that aren't aligned with the final design — the tool will literally try to match them

PART B

Brand tokens

B.1 Colour

The full palette

DEEP INK #1F3A4D	PAPER CREAM #F5F1EA	TERRACOTTA #C9603A
MFG BLACK #000000	STONE #5A6B78	QUIET #9DA8B2

Tokens (paste into your Tailwind/CSS/Figma)

```

--color-bg:           #F5F1EA; /* Paper Cream – default background */
--color-primary:      #1F3A4D; /* Deep Ink – text, wordmark, fish */
--color-text-2:       #5A6B78; /* Stone – captions, secondary */
--color-text-3:       #9DA8B2; /* Quiet – tertiary, disabled */
--color-rule:         #BFC4C9; /* Hairline borders, dividers */
--color-accent:       #C9603A; /* Terracotta – 1% only */
--color-ink-true:     #000000; /* Care labels only – never web */

```

Application ratios

- **Paper Cream** — 75% of every surface. Default state. The brand's air.
- **Deep Ink** — 20%. All text, wordmark, fish. The brand's voice.
- **Stone + Quiet** — 4% combined. Secondary text, dividers, hints.
- **Terracotta** — 1% only. Wax seal, single accent moments. Never as a colour fill.
- **Black** — 0% on web. Reserved for care-label print and embroidery.

Product palette (the five shirts — used only in product photography)

Name	HEX	Pantone TPG	Meaning
Manu White	#F4EFE5	11-0103 TPG	the boat — what carries
Deluge Indigo	#1B2A47	19-3933 TPG	the night — when the rain came
Veda Cream	#EFE6D2	12-0712 TPG	old paper — preserved
Tide Stone	#B8BCB6	16-3802 TPG	wet rock — the boat rested
Coast Olive	#545A3D	18-0523 TPG	dry land — life again

These five colours appear only in product photography — never in UI chrome, never as section backgrounds, never as button colours.

B.2 Typography

Three faces

Role	Recommended	Use
Display / wordmark	Adobe Caslon Pro Bold	'mtsya' wordmark — lowercase, +200 letter-spacing. The same typeface used in Penguin Classics and Aleph Book Company hardcovers.
Headlines + body	Adobe Caslon Pro Roman	Long-form text, founder's letter, product page copy. Free fallback: EB Garamond.
Functional / UI	Optima or Inter	Buttons, captions, prices, navigation labels, sizes. Optima has Roman-inscriptional roots; Inter is the free modern alternative.
Devanagari	Mukta Mahee	मत्स्य and any Hindi/Sanskrit text. Free, by Ek Type Mumbai. Conservative, refined.

Type scale (web, px)

Role	Font	Size	Line ht	Weight	Tracking
Wordmark	Caslon Bold	64–96	1.05	700	+200
H1	Caslon	40–48	1.20	400	0
H2	Caslon	28–32	1.30	400	0
H3 / eyebrow	Optima	14–16	1.30	500	+200
Body	Caslon	17–18	1.55	400	0
Caption	Optima	13–14	1.45	400	+20
Button (caps)	Optima	12–13	1.0	500	+150

Type rules

- Body text always justified-left, ragged-right (web). Justified-both-sides only in InDesign with proper hyphenation (print).

- No italics in headlines. Italics only for foreign words (matsya, pralaya) and the brand book.
- No bold weights in body. The brand voice does not need to shout.
- Numerals: oldstyle in body, lining in tables and prices.
- Smart quotes always. Never straight quotes.
- All-caps allowed only for: wordmark, button labels, eyebrows.
- ₹ symbol always — never 'Rs.' or 'INR' on customer surfaces.

B.3 Spacing & layout

Spacing scale

Token	px	Use
xs	8	Inline gaps, tight UI
sm	16	Paragraph spacing, button padding
md	24	Default block separator, card padding
lg	48	Section gaps within a page
xl	96	Section gaps on the homepage
2xl	128	Hero spacing, top-of-page generosity

Grid

12 columns. Max content width 1440px. Gutter 24px. Side margins: 80px desktop, 24px mobile. Vertical rhythm: 8px increments only.

Borders, radii, shadows

Token	Value	Use
--radius-none	0	Default — buttons, cards, inputs, images
--radius-sm	2 px	Only if absolutely needed — rare
--border-hairline	1 px solid Rule #BFC4C9	Table dividers, image frames
--border-emphasis	2 px solid Deep Ink	Selected states, focus rings
--shadow	NONE	Drop shadows betray the brand. Never use.

PART C

Component library

Every UI element in MTSYA, specified. Each component cites the reference brand whose execution it descends from.

C.1 Header / navigation

Reference: The Row, Lemaire — single line, flat, no dropdowns until necessary

A single horizontal line, 80px tall on desktop, 64px on mobile. Logo (mtsya wordmark only, no fish) on left. Five navigation items max on right: 'shirts', 'tees', 'the story', 'journal', 'bag'. All in Optima 14px, all-caps, +150 letter-spacing, Deep Ink. No dropdowns. No mega-menus. The header is transparent over hero images, becomes solid Paper Cream on scroll.

height:	80px (desktop), 64px (mobile)
background:	transparent on hero, Paper Cream on scroll
logo:	left-aligned, mtsya wordmark, 24px height
nav items:	5 max, Optima 14px caps +150, right-aligned
border-bottom:	1px Rule, only when scrolled

C.2 Footer

Reference: Lemaire, Loro Piana — sparse, no banner, no newsletter spam

Three columns on desktop, stacked on mobile. Column one: brand block — small fish + 'mtsya' + brand promise ('the wardrobe that endures the deluge'). Column two: navigation — 'shirts / tees / the story / journal / contact'. Column three: a single email signup field (no banner, no animation, just a serif input and a navy 'subscribe' button). Below: legal — © 2026 MTSYA · Made in India · Privacy · Returns. Background: Paper Cream. Text: Stone. Padding 96px top and bottom.

padding:	96px top + bottom, 48px sides
background:	Paper Cream
text colour:	Stone (#5A6B78)
font:	Optima 13px for nav, Caslon 14px for brand block
layout:	3 columns equal width, stacked < 768px

C.3 Hero

Reference: The Row, Lemaire — single full-screen image, no overlay text, no carousel

Full viewport width and height (100vw × 100vh). One image only — never a carousel. The image is mood 'Worn' (real man wearing the shirt in his life) at launch, rotating to mood 'Still' (shirt photographed alone) seasonally. No overlay text on the image. No CTA button on the image. The viewer scrolls down to the founder's letter; the image is the welcome.

dimensions:	100vw × 100vh
content:	single image, no overlay
transitions:	none — single static image
image style:	'Worn' or 'Still' (see brand book Appendix D)

C.4 Product card

Reference: Aesop, Lemaire — pure image, no fill, no border, no shadow

On product listing pages. Each card is a single 4:5 portrait image of the shirt on cream background, shot from the front, single garment, no model. Below the image: 16px gap, then product name (e.g. 'Manu White') in Caslon 18px Roman; below that, an italic subtitle ('the boat — what carries') in Caslon Italic 14px Stone; below that, 8px gap, then price ('₹3,000') in Optima 14px. No 'add to bag' button on the card — clicking the card opens the full product page. No hover effects beyond a 200ms opacity dim of the image.

image:	4:5 portrait, single garment on cream, no border
title:	Caslon 18px Roman, Deep Ink
subtitle:	Caslon Italic 14px, Stone
price:	Optima 14px, Deep Ink, oldstyle figures
hover:	opacity 0.85, 200ms ease
no buttons, no badges, no 'sale' tags, no quick-add	

C.5 Product listing grid

Reference: Loro Piana, Aesop — generous, never more than 3 across

Maximum three products per row on desktop. Two on tablet. One on mobile. Vertical gap between rows: 96px. Horizontal gap between cards: 48px. With only 5 shirts at launch, the entire collection fits on one screen above the fold on a 1440px display. This is a feature, not a constraint — the buyer sees the whole world at once.

columns:	3 desktop / 2 tablet / 1 mobile
row gap:	96px
col gap:	48px
max products visible above fold (desktop): 5-6	

C.6 Product detail page

Reference: Loro Piana, Aesop — image dominant, text below, fabric story prominent

Two-column layout above fold on desktop, stacked on mobile.

LEFT COLUMN (60% width): One large hero image of the shirt, 4:5 ratio, centred with cream margin. Below: three small thumbnail images (still / worn / detail), 96px tall, evenly spaced. Click thumbnail to swap hero.

RIGHT COLUMN (40% width): Product name in Caslon 36px (e.g. 'Manu White'). Subtitle in Caslon Italic 18px Stone ('the boat. the foundational shirt.'). 24px gap. Price in Optima 18px. 24px gap. Fit selector (three pills: SLIM / MODERN / RELAXED). 16px gap. Size selector (five pills: XS S M L XL). 24px gap. Single button: 'ADD TO BAG' in cream-on-navy, full width of column.

BELOW THE FOLD (full width): The fabric story — about 150 words of Caslon body in two columns, on the cloth (Egyptian Giza × TENCEL), the mill, why it drapes the way it does. Two more images: macro of the weave, and a worn detail (the cuff, the placket). Below: care instructions in 6 lines max. No 'you may also like' carousel. No reviews section by default — the brand earns trust through the brand book and the founder's letter, not through 4-star ratings.

```
// Above fold – two column
.product-hero { display: grid; grid-template-columns: 60% 40%; gap: 48px; }

// Below fold – fabric story
.fabric-story { columns: 2; column-gap: 48px; max-width: 960px; margin: 96px auto; }
```

C.7 Buttons

Reference: The Row, Lemaire — square, no shadow, two variants only

Primary

```
background:    Deep Ink #1F3A4D
text:          Paper Cream #F5F1EA
font:          Optima 13px, ALL CAPS, +150 letter-spacing, weight 500
padding:       16px vertical, 32px horizontal
radius:        0
hover:         background → #15293A (10% darker), 200ms
disabled:      background → Stone #5A6B78
```

Secondary (ghost)

background:	transparent
border:	1px solid Deep Ink
text:	Deep Ink, Optima 13px caps
padding:	16px / 32px
hover:	background → Deep Ink, text → Paper Cream, 200ms

That is the entire button system. There is no third variant. There are no 'success', 'warning', or 'danger' colours — MTSYA is a clothing brand, not a SaaS product. Errors are written in Deep Ink, with one line of stone-coloured Optima below explaining the issue.

C.8 Inputs

Reference: Brunello Cucinelli — bottom-border only, never boxed inputs

background:	Paper Cream
border:	none
border-bottom:	1px solid Stone #5A6B78
padding:	12px 0 (no horizontal padding)
font:	Caslon Roman 17px, Deep Ink
placeholder:	Quiet #9DA8B2
focus:	border-bottom thickens to 2px Deep Ink, 200ms
error:	border-bottom → Terracotta, 1 line of message below in Optima 13px

Labels appear ABOVE the input, in Optima 13px caps +200, Stone colour. The label is always visible — never a placeholder-only 'floating label'. The brand respects the customer enough to tell them what each field is.

C.9 Cards & containers

Reference: Aesop — there are no card containers. The image is the card.

MTSYA does not use card containers in the standard sense. There are no rounded-corner panels with drop shadows containing content. Layout is achieved through generous whitespace between elements, hairline rules where division is essential, and the natural framing of well-shot images. If you find yourself reaching for a 'card' component, you are probably reaching for a Bootstrap habit. Ask: would Loro Piana wrap this in a card? They wouldn't. Don't.

C.10 Divider

```
.divider { border-top: 1px solid #BFC4C9; margin: 48px 0; }
```

That's it. One pixel of Rule grey, 48px breathing room above and below. Used at most twice on any page — between the hero and the content, and between the content and the footer. Anything more is decoration.

C.11 Image frame

Images have no borders, no shadows, no rounded corners. Aspect ratios allowed: 4:5 (product), 3:2 (lifestyle), 1:1 (Instagram crops, brand-system only). Background behind every image: Paper Cream. Images load with a 200ms fade-in, no skeleton loaders with shimmer animations (those betray the brand).

```
img { border: 0; border-radius: 0; box-shadow: none; }
.image-loading { opacity: 0; transition: opacity 200ms; }
.image-loaded { opacity: 1; }
```

C.12 Iconography

Reference: *The Row, Lemaire, Loro Piana* — language replaces icons

The single hardest rule of the system: NO ICONS IN THE UI. Every icon you would normally use, MTSYA replaces with language.

Where you'd use an icon	MTSYA uses instead	Why
Cart icon ()	'bag (2)' as text link	Loro Piana, Lemaire, The Row all use the word
Hamburger menu ()	'menu' as text link	Mobile menu opens the same nav as desktop, just stacked
Search magnifier ()	'search' link, opens an input	With only 10 SKUs, search is rarely needed
Account / user icon ()	'account' link	Or just 'sign in' if not logged in
Heart / wishlist	Don't have a wishlist	With 5 shirts, the customer doesn't need to save things
Social icons in footer	'instagram' as text link	Underlined Optima 13px, Stone colour
Star ratings ()	Don't have ratings	The brand book and founder's letter earn trust

Where you'd use an icon	MTSYA uses instead	Why
ARROW ICONS (← →)	'previous' / 'next' as text	Or just don't have pagination

EXCEPTION: the fish emblem itself, used at the close of the founder's letter, on the favicon, and as a small mark at the end of email footers. That is the only graphic mark in the entire UI. Everything else is type.

PART D

Page layouts

Every page in the website, anatomically described. Each page cites the reference brands whose homepage / product page / cart it descends from.

D.1 Homepage

Reference: The Row (homepage discipline), Lemaire (single-image hero), Brunello Cucinelli (founder's letter prominent)

Above the fold

One full-screen image (mood 'Worn'). No overlay text. No CTA button. No carousel. The image is the welcome.

Below the fold (the founder's letter)

96px of breathing space. Then the founder's letter, in Caslon body, 18px, line-height 1.55, set in a single column at 65 characters wide. Centred in the page. About 600 words. Written in first person by the founder, never edited by marketing. Closes with a small fish emblem, then a single line link: 'the five shirts →'.

Below the founder's letter

128px of breathing space. Then the homepage product preview — a single image of one shirt (rotates per visit), with the word 'shirts' as a Caslon 32px link below. Clicking goes to /shirts. Below that, similarly: 'tees', 'the story', 'journal'. Four sections, one image each, vertically stacked. Each at 80vh. The homepage scrolls slowly.

Footer

Standard footer (see C.2).

TOTAL PAGE LENGTH: roughly 6 viewport heights, mostly image and breathing space. The user scrolls deliberately. The brand rewards them for it.

D.2 Shop / shirts listing page

Reference: Aesop, Loro Piana — generous grid, no filters, 5 SKUs only

URL: /shirts. Header. 96px space. Page title in Caslon H1 32px, Stone: 'the five shirts'. 48px space. A short paragraph in Caslon body 18px, 65ch wide, centred — about 80 words on what

these are: 'Five shirts, each named for a moment in the myth. Made of Egyptian Giza cotton woven with TENCEL Lyocell. ₹3,000 each. Three fits. Restocked every eight weeks; the silhouettes do not change.'

Below: the grid. Three columns desktop (so all five fit in two rows with one image standing alone — which is fine, even desirable). Each card uses the spec from C.4. No filter sidebar. No sort dropdown. With five products, filtering is absurd.

Below grid: 96px. Then a small line in Caslon italic 18px Stone: '— and five plain T-shirts.' This is a link to /tees.

D.3 Product detail page

Reference: Loro Piana, Aesop — material story dominant, no upsells

Full spec already covered in C.6. The product page is the most important commerce page in the brand. It is never to be A/B-tested with conversion-rate-optimisation logic. Changes happen by deliberation, not data.

D.4 The story (about page)

Reference: Brunello Cucinelli (Solomeo essays), 11.11 (process pages)

URL: /the-story. This is where the brand book lives, in chapter form. One page per chapter, Caslon body, paged navigation at the bottom ('chapter one of eight →'). The chapters from the brand book are reproduced verbatim. Each chapter ends with the fish emblem and a chapter pagination.

This is the most-read page on the website after the homepage and product pages. The buyer comes here to learn what they are about to buy into. Treat it as the brand's most important asset.

D.5 The journal

Reference: Lemaire (long-form essays), Aesop (Issue magazine)

URL: /journal. A list of essays, one per quarter. Each essay is between 1,200 and 3,500 words. Topics: the mill the fabric is made in, a craft tradition the brand draws on, an interview with a wearer, a Sanskrit word that doesn't translate, an essay on what a wardrobe is. Each essay is illustrated with one or two photographs from the World mood. No 'featured posts' module, no related posts at the bottom — each essay stands alone.

D.6 Cart

Reference: Lemaire — stripped, no upsells

URL: /bag. (Not /cart — that's icon-language, not brand-language.)

Single column, Caslon Roman type, generous spacing. Each item is a row: small image (96px square) on the left, product name + colour + size + fit in the middle, price on the right, with a small 'remove' link below the product name in Stone colour. No quantity selector for 99% of cases — the buyer adds one shirt at a time. (If they really need two, they add to bag twice.)

Below the items: subtotal in Optima 18px, 'Free shipping in India' as a single sentence (always true, not an offer), and a 'CONTINUE TO CHECKOUT' primary button. Below: a single sentence in Caslon italic 14px Stone: 'Returns within 30 days, no questions, no need to explain.' That is the trust statement. There is no FAQ accordion. There are no upsell suggestions. There is no 'people who bought this also bought' module.

D.7 Checkout

Reference: Lemaire — three steps, clean, fast

Three steps, on three pages: address, shipping, payment. Each page has a single column, the brand header reduced to just the wordmark, no footer. Fields use the input spec from C.8 (bottom-border only). The CTA at the bottom of each step is a primary button: 'CONTINUE'. The final step's button is 'PLACE ORDER · ₹X,XXX' (with the total inline). After payment, the order confirmation page IS the founder's letter, in full, with the order details quietly underneath.

D.8 Order confirmation email

Reference: Aesop — the email is a letter

Subject line: 'Your MTSYA shirt is ordered.' (period, no exclamation). From: 'kushal at mtsya' (lowercase, no pretentious title). Body: a short note from the founder thanking them, the order details below in Optima 14px, the founder's signature, the fish at the close. Total length: about 200 words. No tracking links yet (the shipping email handles that). No 'follow us on Instagram' line.

D.9 Shipping notification email

Subject: 'On its way.' Body: 'Your MTSYA shirt left the studio this morning. It will arrive in 2–4 days. Track it here.' That's it. One line of body copy plus a tracking link.

D.10 404 page

'This page is not here. The brand is small. Most of it is at /shirts.' Set in Caslon H2 32px, centred on a near-empty Paper Cream page, with the small fish below.

D.11 Search results

If implemented at all (probably year two). Single search input, 30 character placeholder: 'a colour, a fit'. Results are simple text links to product pages. No image thumbnails — with 10 SKUs, the customer can read the names.

D.12 Mobile patterns

Mobile is not a separate experience. It is the same brand, re-flowed. Specifically:

- Header: 64px, mtsya wordmark left, 'menu' text right (no hamburger)
- Hero: 100vh, single image
- Product grid: single column, full width minus 24px gutter
- Product detail: image stack, then info, then fabric story (single column)
- Cart: single column
- Buttons: full-width with 24px side padding
- Type: same scale as desktop minus 2–4px on each level

PART E

Anti-patterns

If MTSYA dies young, it will probably die in one of these specific ways. Reread quarterly.

E.1 Visual anti-patterns

- Drop shadows on anything
- Gradients (background, text, button — never)
- Rounded corners > 2px
- Animation on scroll (parallax, fade-in cascades, 'aos' libraries)
- Skeleton loaders with shimmer animations
- Carousels (homepage, product, anywhere)
- Pop-ups (newsletter signup, cookie banner, exit-intent)
- Sticky 'scroll back to top' arrows
- Live chat widgets in the bottom right
- Stock photography of any kind
- 'As seen in' press logo bars
- Trust-seal badges ('100% Secure Checkout', 'Verified by Visa')
- Third-party review widgets (Trustpilot, Yotpo)
- Discount countdown timers

E.2 Copy anti-patterns

- Exclamation marks (almost never)
- Emojis in customer-facing copy
- ALL CAPS for emphasis in body
- 'Hurry, only 2 left in stock!' urgency text
- 'Free shipping on orders over ₹X' (shipping is free, full stop)
- Words: premium, luxury, curated, drop, alert, amazing, crafted, must-have

E.3 Commerce anti-patterns

- Sales (end-of-season, festival, anniversary — no)
- Discount codes (the price is the price)
- BOGO offers
- Bundles ('shirt + tee for 10% off')
- Subscription / auto-replenish models
- Affiliate / influencer codes
- Marketplace listings (Myntra, Flipkart, Amazon, Ajio) for at least 18 months
- Performance marketing (Meta, Google ads) at scale in year one

E.4 Structural anti-patterns

- Adding products faster than once per quarter (the brand is built on five and five)
- Founder-personality marketing in year one (the founder is silent for the first eighteen months)
- Influencer 'seeding' in exchange for posts
- Free product to mid-tier influencers
- Pinterest as a moodboard source for new collections
- Logo on chest, ever

PART F

Reference brand studies

Each of MTSYA's reference brands, with the specific lesson to take and what to leave. Spend an afternoon on each website before any major design decision.

The Row

URL: therow.com. Founded 2006 by the Olsen sisters.

TAKE: the homepage discipline. Single image, no carousel, minimal nav, no overlay text. The product grid generosity. The way they refuse to put faces on the founders. Their year-one vow of silence.

LEAVE: their price point (much higher), their black-and-white photography exclusively (MTSYA uses cream backgrounds).

Lemaire

URL: lemaire.fr. Christophe Lemaire's house, current era.

TAKE: the earth-tone palette discipline (chocolates, ecru, navy with rare burnished orange). The product page layout — single image dominant, type below. The footer (sparse, no banner). The geometric letterforms in their wordmark — same logic as 'mtsya' as a flat geometric word.

LEAVE: their European-only product photography. MTSYA's photography includes Indian interiors and Indian morning light.

Toteme

URL: toteme-studio.com. Stockholm, founded 2014.

TAKE: the custom typography approach. The sharp, no-frills product photography. The 'less is more' product page restraint. The decisive, direct copy voice.

LEAVE: the cold Scandinavian palette — MTSYA is warmer, Indian-rooted.

Brunello Cucinelli

URL: brunellocucinelli.com. The Italian humanist-luxury master.

TAKE: the storytelling page style — long essays, philosophical prose, large warm photography of the village of Solomeo. MTSYA's 'the story' page is built on this template. Also: the way they treat the brand's place (Solomeo) as a character. MTSYA does the same with the brand's myth.

LEAVE: the formal serif logo (theirs is austere, MTSYA's is folk-art warm).

Loro Piana

URL: loropiana.com. The Italian fabric house.

TAKE: the material storytelling. Every product page leads with the fibre, the source, the process. MTSYA's product pages descend directly. Also: the material photography — close-up of the cloth, in soft light, almost still life.

LEAVE: their kummel red interior signature (we have terracotta but used differently).

Hermès

URL: hermes.com. The reference for everything.

TAKE: the packaging-as-brand discipline. The orange box is more recognised than the logo; MTSYA's cream box with embossed fish is built on the same logic. The website's editorial richness — long-form essays, beautifully photographed, never selling explicitly.

LEAVE: the price point, the orange accent (we have terracotta), the heritage references (MTSYA has its own myth).

Aesop

URL: aesop.com. The Australian apothecary brand.

TAKE: the typography hierarchy — clean serifs, generous spacing, the way they let copy breathe. The product page's ingredient-led narrative — every product leads with what's in it, not with how good it is. MTSYA's fabric-led product pages descend from this template. Also: their email voice (the email IS a letter), and their store design (warm wood, dim lighting, library aesthetic).

LEAVE: the apothecary categorisation system — MTSYA has five products, not fifty.

11.11 / eleven eleven

URL: 11-11.in. The Indian quiet-luxury reference.

TAKE: the indigo discipline (MTSYA's deep ink is the menswear cousin). The way they treat material as a process, not a feature. The flagship store's indigo passage as a design idea — MTSYA's box is the equivalent moment, the buyer's first sensory experience of the brand world. The Indian-craft-luxury voice without folk-art surface.

LEAVE: their multi-product range (kurtas, dresses, etc.) — MTSYA stays in plain shirts.

Nicobar

URL: nicobar.com. The Good Earth lineage's modern Indian quiet-luxury house.

TAKE: the way they pair restrained palette with subtle Indian voice. The 'alphabet series' typographic experiments. The lifestyle-but-disciplined photography mood.

LEAVE: the unisex / lifestyle product range — MTSYA is menswear-focused.

Raw Mango

URL: rawmango.com. Sanjay Garg's house. The most uncompromising brand on this list.

TAKE: the 'Indian without kitsch' principle — quote it, frame it, hang it on the studio wall. The use of forest green on cream as a colour pairing (terracotta on cream is MTSYA's equivalent). The surreal, slightly editorial product photography. The willingness to be unashamed about cultural depth.

LEAVE: the runway-occasion-wear DNA (MTSYA is daily wear).

Closing

This document is opinionated by design. Every choice has a reason. Most of those reasons are in the brand book. If a choice in this document seems wrong, the right move is to disagree with the

principle behind it — not to change the value silently. Update the brand book first; then update this document; then update the website. Never the other way around.

The brand will outlive any single designer, any specific tool, any one founder. It will not outlive the system being broken silently by people who didn't ask why.

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मत्स्य

the wardrobe that endures the deluge

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MTSYA Design System & Web Component Guidelines · Edition 1.0 · May 2026 · Update annually, by one person, with deliberation.